

MONTH TO MONTH

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. GRAND HOUSE - CONSERVATORY - DAY

A concert grand in a room nobody lives in. Dust sheets on every other piece of furniture. Not on the piano.

DEV (30s), tuning kit open like a surgeon's roll, leans into the strings. He plays one note. Listens. Plays it again.

A HOMEOWNER (60s) watches from the doorway, phone in hand, already elsewhere.

DEV
Who plays?

HOMEOWNER
Nobody, currently.

DEV
It's in beautiful shape for nobody.

HOMEOWNER
It just has to be ready.

Dev nods like that's a normal thing for a piano to be. He strikes the note a third time. Perfect now.

Nobody will ever hear it.

MAIN TITLE: MONTH TO MONTH

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - EVENING

Small, warm, lived-in. An upright piano against one wall, sheet music in stacks. Two plates out.

MARA (30s) moves around the kitchen like she was issued with it. She knows which drawer sticks. She knows the burner that lies about being lit.

At the table, she takes a clementine from the bowl and peels it in one unbroken spiral. Doesn't look at her hands while she does it. Sets the spiral on the table like a little sculpture and splits the fruit – half for her, half slid across to Dev.

DEV
One day you'll tear it and I'll
know you're mortal.

MARA
One day.

He eats his half. This has happened a hundred times. It is nobody's favourite part of the day, officially.

It is both of their favourite part of the day.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Later. Mara's legs across his lap. The TV murmuring. Her phone on the arm of the couch – face down. It is always face down, and it is always at a hundred percent.

DEV
Stay Sunday. I'll do the eggs you
pretend not to like.

MARA
I have my thing Sunday.

DEV
You always have your thing Sunday.

MARA
(kissing his head, up and
moving)
And you always ask on Thursday.

He smiles. It's a joke between them.

He has never once asked what the thing is. Some doors you don't knock on when you're happy.

INT. REHEARSAL HALL - DAY

Dev tunes an old upright in the corner of a community hall. A KIDS' CHOIR files in early, chaos on legs. He works through it, unbothered. This piano gets played. He likes this one.

His phone BUZZES on the lid. An email notification, glanced at with one eye:

INSERT - PHONE

PAYMENT FAILED – YOUR PLAN WILL PAUSE. Update your billing within 7 days to avoid an interruption in service.

BACK TO SCENE. Sender: some company. Logo like a sunrise. He swipes it away the way you swipe away a gym you never joined and a newsletter you never read.

Spam. Everybody's spam is bad.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Dinner. Mara mid-story, doing all the voices. Dev laughing, properly laughing.

MARA
– and the conductor just stands
there, baton up, like the orchestra
might start apologizing –

DEV
Stubborn as a Sunday.

MARA
(delighted)
Stubborn as a Sunday! Your dad's
line.

The room goes half a degree colder. Dev's fork stops.

DEV
I never told you that was his.

MARA
(no gap at all)
You did. First month. The wedding
story – your cousin's wedding, the
best man's speech.

A wedding he did tell her about. Probably. It was a good
night, there was wine. A hundred honest explanations, and he
only needs one.

He picks one.

DEV
Stubborn as a Sunday.

She spirals a clementine. Half for her, half for him. The
peel sits between them like a signature.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - LATER

Mara asleep against his shoulder. The TV off. His phone in
his free hand, dim.

The email, un-swiped this time. He reads it properly.

INSERT - PHONE

Your COMPANION plan (Tier 2) will pause on the 31st.
Gifted subscription – purchaser: H. NARAYAN.
We know how much this relationship means to you.

BACK TO SCENE. H. Narayan.

His sister.

Dev sits very still, the way you do when moving would make it true. Mara breathes against his shoulder, warm, real, asleep.

On the table, the spiral of peel, drying into a curl.

INT. HANNA'S CAR - DAY

Parked outside a school. HANNA (40s) in the driver's seat, kids' cleats and chaos in the back. Dev in the passenger seat, staring ahead.

DEV
Eleven months.

HANNA
Dev —

DEV
Eleven months, Han.

HANNA
(quiet, not sorry
enough, or maybe
exactly sorry enough)
You didn't leave the apartment.
After Dad. You tuned pianos and you
came home and you sat in the dark
and you stopped calling me back.
(beat)
It was supposed to be dinners. A
few dinners. Company. They said
most people cancel inside a month —
they tell you that up front, like a
gym.

DEV
And when I didn't cancel?

HANNA
You didn't know there was anything
to cancel.

He looks at her. The worst part is that she's not wrong about the dark apartment. The worst part has several candidates, actually, and they're all doing well.

HANNA (CONT'D)

She was supposed to tell you by month three. That's their policy. Disclosure.

(beat)

I got an email in March saying the file had been – retained. Flagged. Something. I thought it meant it was going fine.

DEV

It was going fine.

He gets out of the car. Doesn't slam the door. That's the saddest available option, and he takes it.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Dev alone at the table with his laptop. The company's website. Warm gradients. Faces at farmers' markets.

COMPANIONSHIP, MONTH TO MONTH. The way it should be: no contracts, no pressure, real connection.

He scrolls. Testimonials. A FAQ.

"Are your companions real people?" – Yes. Our companions are trained professionals who bring genuine warmth to every plan.

"Can I meet my companion outside the plan?" – For everyone's safety, companions may not maintain contact after a plan ends.

He closes the laptop. The bowl of clementines sits there, looking guilty of nothing.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - EVENING

The buzzer. He lets her up. Some number of seconds pass, the exact number it always takes, and then her knock – two, then one.

He opens the door. Mara. Groceries in one arm, rain in her hair, glad to see him.

The film holds on his face deciding.

MARA

They had the good bread.

DEV

Course they did.

He takes the bag. He says nothing. He watches her move through his kitchen – the sticky drawer, the lying burner – and for the first time he sees the craft in it. The homeowner's voice, unbidden: it just has to be ready.

She catches him staring.

MARA
What?

DEV
Long day. Old piano fighting me.

MARA
Did you win?

DEV
I always win. That's the sad part.

Dinner happens. It's lovely. That's the sadder part.

After, she takes a clementine and begins the spiral.

DEV
Mara.

She looks up. Something in his voice. Her thumb pauses mid-peel.

DEV (CONT'D)
Do you like this? Any of this?

A silence with machinery in it. She could deploy something warm here. He can see the shelf of warm things behind her eyes, fully stocked.

She doesn't reach for it.

MARA
You're not supposed to ask me that.

DEV
Says who?

She sets down the clementine, half-spiralled.

MARA
Says the part of this that's a job,
Dev.

The word lands in the kitchen and everything in the room becomes inventory. The two plates. The sheet music she bought him in month four. The second toothbrush.

DEV
The thirty-first. That's real?

MARA
(quiet)
That's real.

DEV
And you knew I didn't know.

A long beat. She doesn't look away. He'll think about that later – that she didn't look away.

MARA
By month three I was supposed to
tell you or close the file.
(beat)
I kept moving you to the top of the
renewal queue instead. There's a
box I tick. I've ticked it eight
times.

DEV
Why?

MARA
You're not supposed to ask me that
either.

She picks up the clementine. Finishes the spiral, one
unbroken curl, hands steady, eyes not.

Half for her. Half slid across to him.

He doesn't touch it.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - LATER

The door. Her coat on. The ordinary choreography of leaving,
performed at half speed.

MARA
If the plan lapses, there's a call.
They'll offer you a transition
companion. It's seamless. People
rate it very highly.

DEV
Seamless.

MARA
That's the product, Dev. No seams.

She stands in the doorway. Sunday-shaped silence.

DEV
Your thing. Sundays.

MARA
(a small, terrible
smile)
Somebody else's Thursday.

The door closes on her. He stands there hearing her steps go down – and stop. A long pause on the landing.

Then, faint, through the door: two knocks. Then one.

By the time he opens it, the stairwell is empty.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - DAY

The 31st. Dev at the table with his phone. The renewal screen. UPDATE BILLING – KEEP EVERYTHING THE WAY IT IS.

One tap and nothing has to be true.

His thumb hovers. On the table: the bowl of clementines. The upright piano behind him, in beautiful shape, ready.

He puts the phone down, screen up, and lets the clock run out on it. The screen dims on its own. That's his answer – he doesn't cancel it. He just doesn't save it.

INT. DEV'S APARTMENT - EVENING - DAYS LATER

The apartment, quieter. One plate drying on the rack. Dev at the piano, actually playing – clumsy, honest, a man tuning himself for once. Wrong note. He leaves it wrong.

The BUZZER.

He stops playing. Goes to the intercom. On the little screen: a WOMAN (30s) he has never met, warm-eyed, patient, a paper grocery bag in one arm.

WOMAN (V.O.)
(through the intercom,
bright)
Dev? Hi! I know this is out of the
blue – I'm a friend of Hanna's.
She thought you could use some
company.

DEV
...Which friend?

A half-second. The exact length of a shelf being reached for.

WOMAN (V.O.)
From her book club!

Dev almost smiles. Eleven months of listening to pianos.
That's the product with no seams, and he just heard one.

Out of the top of her grocery bag, unmistakable in the
lobby light: clementines.

Dev looks at them for a long time. The intercom hums,
patient. Behind him, on the kitchen table, Mara's last
spiral has dried into a perfect curl.

His finger rests on the button. Not pressing. Resting.

Somewhere in the building, a piano nobody plays stays
perfectly in tune.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END